AMERICAN PLACES

1.4 The Mississippi River



The mighty Mississippi is the largest river in North America and one of the largest in the world. It lies entirely within the United States and flows south from Minnesota, collecting water from the Ohio and Missouri rivers and spilling from Louisiana into the Gulf of Mexico. As one of the world's busiest commercial waterways, the river is the lifeblood of a highly industrialized country. It snakes through some of the nation's most fertile farmland and moves most of our agricultural exports. The unique role the Mississippi has played in American history and literature has woven it deeply into the fabric of the country's folklore. As American author Mark Twain once said, "The Mississippi River will always have its own way; no engineering skill can persuade it to do otherwise." How might a geologic feature like a river serve as a "character" in a book?

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CRITICAL VIEWING Steamboats have been chugging down the Mississippi River since the early 1800s, transforming how people and goods moved across the United States. Examine the front of the first steamboat (left) and the rear of the second steamboat (right). What can you infer about how these boats move through the water?

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